

While all across society the rich are growing richer, there are vast segments of the American citizenry where the poor remain abjectly poor. For example, according to a recent study in the *New York Times*, the wealthiest 5 percent of residents of Manhattan earned more than \$500,000 in 2006, and the top 20 percent earned more than \$300,000. But the poorest 20 percent of wage earners took home an average pay of just \$8,855. Think of that!

I share the concern of *New York Times* columnist David Brooks about what he describes as “this stark financial polarization.”

On the one hand, there is the investor class. It has tax-deferred savings plans, as well as an army of financial advisers. [On the other hand,] there is the lottery class, people with little access to 401(k)s or financial planning but plenty of access to payday lenders, credit cards and lottery agents. . . . The loosening of financial inhibition has meant more options for the well-educated but more temptation and chaos for the most vulnerable. Social norms, the invisible threads that guide behavior, have deteriorated. Over the past years, Americans have been more socially conscious about protecting the environment and inhaling tobacco. They have become less socially conscious about money and debt.

We who are members of what David Brooks describes as the investor class can feel proud of our good fortune and our thrift. But even as we thrive on the great benefits of our American civilization, we must remind ourselves that these benefits are not shared by far too large a portion of our citizenry. The Declaration of Independence assures us “that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.”

While we all may be created equal, however, we are born into a society where inequality—of family, of education, and, yes, even of opportunity—begins as soon as birth takes place. But our Constitution demands more. “We the People” are enjoined “to form a